Digital Documentation (Advanced)

The big idea

In Class 9 you learnt to type and format in **LibreOffice Writer**. In Class 10 you learn the power tools that make long, professional documents easy: **styles**, **images and drawing objects**, **templates**, an automatic **table of contents**, and **mail merge** for sending personalised letters to many people.

Styles

A **style** is a saved set of formatting (font, size, colour, spacing, indent) with a name. Change the style once and every part using it updates. Open the **Styles** deck with **View > Styles** or **F11**.

LibreOffice has these style categories:

Category	Applies to
Paragraph	Whole paragraphs – headings, body text
Character	Selected words or letters
Frame	Frames and images
Page	Margins, size, headers/footers, orientation
List	Bullets and numbering
Table	Table formatting

Ways to apply a style: double-click its name in the Styles deck; use the **Set Paragraph Style** box on the Formatting toolbar; use **Fill Format Mode** (the paint-

can icon) to apply a style by clicking; or shortcuts (**Ctrl+1** Heading 1, **Ctrl+2** Heading 2, **Ctrl+0** Body Text).

CREATE A NEW STYLE FROM SELECTION

1. Format a paragraph the way you want (e.g. Arial 14, blue).
2. In the Styles deck, click the **Styles actions** menu → **New Style from Selection**.
3. Type a name, e.g. *MyHeading*, and click **OK**.
   To change it later, right-click the style → **Modify**. To match a style to edited text, use **Update Selected Style**. **Load Styles** copies styles from another document or template.

Images and drawing objects

Insert a picture with **Insert > Image**, choose the file, click **Open**. You can also drag and drop, copy-paste, or scan (**Insert > Media > Scan**). Right-click an image to:

- **Crop** – remove unwanted edges (**Format > Image > Properties > Crop** tab).
- **Resize** – drag corner handles (hold Shift to keep the ratio) or set size in **Properties > Type**.
- **Rotate** – **Format > Rotate or Flip**.
- **Wrap** – how text flows around: None, Parallel, Optimal, Before, After, Through.
- **Anchor** – To Page, To Paragraph, To Character, As Character.

Draw shapes with the **Drawing** toolbar (**View > Toolbars > Drawing**). Select several objects with Shift+click and **Format > Group > Group** to move them as one.

Templates

A **template** is a model document whose styles and layout are reused for new documents (e.g. a school letterhead). Writer templates have the extension **.ott**.

- Create: design the document → **File > Templates > Save as Template** → name it, choose a category → **Save**.
- Use: **File > New > Templates** (Ctrl+Shift+N) → double-click the template.
- Set as default: in the Templates dialog, right-click → **Set as Default**.

Table of contents

Writer builds a table of contents (ToC) automatically from **heading styles**.

1. Apply Heading 1, Heading 2 … to your headings.
2. Place the cursor where the ToC should go.
3. **Insert > Table of Contents and Index > Table of Contents, Index or Bibliography**.
4. Set title, type and levels (Type tab); adjust Entries, Styles, Columns, Background tabs; click **OK**.

Update after editing: right-click the ToC → **Update Index**, or **Tools > Update > Update All**. To remove: right-click → **Delete Index**.

BOLD TEXT IS NOT A HEADING

A ToC only picks up text formatted with heading (outline-level) styles. Simply making text bold and big will not include it.

Mail merge

Mail merge combines a **main document** (the common letter) with a **data source** (names, addresses) to produce many personalised letters, labels or envelopes.

- **Data source** can be a Calc sheet, Base database, Writer table or CSV file.

- Start: **Tools > Mail Merge Wizard**. Its 8 steps: select starting document → select document type (letter/e-mail) → insert address block → create salutation → adjust layout → edit document → personalise documents → save, print or send.
- Without the wizard: register the data source (**File > New > Database** or **Edit > Exchange Database**), open **View > Data Sources** (Ctrl+Shift+F4), and drag field names into the letter as **fields**.

REMEMBER THE THREE PARTS

Main document + data source = merged documents. Board questions often ask you to name them.

Quick recap

- Styles (F11): paragraph, character, frame, page, list, table.
- Images: Insert > Image; crop, resize, rotate, wrap, anchor; group drawing objects.
- Templates (.ott): File > Templates > Save as Template.
- ToC: built from heading styles; Insert > Table of Contents and Index.
- Mail merge: Tools > Mail Merge Wizard, main document + data source.

Practice questions

1. Which key opens the Styles deck in LibreOffice Writer?
   (a) F7 (b) F11 (c) F5 (d) F12
2. Which style category would you use to set margins and orientation?
   (a) Paragraph style (b) Character style (c) Frame style (d) Page style
3. The default extension of a LibreOffice Writer template is
   (a) .odt (b) .ott (c) .ots (d) .dot
4. To update a table of contents after adding new headings, you should
   (a) delete and retype it (b) press F11 (c) right-click it and choose Update Index (d) save the file as a template
5. Which is NOT a valid data source for mail merge in LibreOffice?
   (a) A Calc spreadsheet (b) A Base database (c) A CSV text file (d) A JPEG image
6. To move several drawing shapes together as one object, you should
   (a) group them using Format > Group > Group (b) anchor them as character (c) apply a paragraph style (d) crop them
7. Fill Format Mode in Writer is used to
   (a) fill a table with data (b) insert an image (c) apply a selected style by clicking on text (d) merge two documents
8. What is a template? Write the steps to create a template in Writer.
9. Explain mail merge. Name its main components and write the menu path to start the wizard.

Answers: 1. b 2. d 3. b 4. c 5. d 6. a 7. c 8. see notes 9. see notes